

Why we like the buildings we like

A thoughtful and provocative book explores the origins of differing tastes in architectural styles

By Robert Campbell
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It's rare that you can recommend to the general reader a book about architecture. Too many books on that topic are clotted attempts at philosophy that read as if they'd been mistranslated from the German. Or they're sales jobs,

plugging some single architect or point of view. Or they're stuffed with too many facts and dates. Or they're overpriced picture books.

It's a joy, therefore, to applaud a new title that's none of those things. Well, almost new — I'm late getting to it. "The Architecture of Happiness," by Alain de

Botton, a Swiss writer who lives in London, is the best introduction to architecture I have ever seen.

De Botton isn't an architect himself, nor a historian of art and architecture. He seems, in fact, to write about everything. I hated his last book, which was inane titled "How Proust Can Change Your Life." I don't much like the title of this one, either, because it makes architecture sound like some New Age blissfulness drug. One reviewer called the book "cultural Valium." Don't believe it.

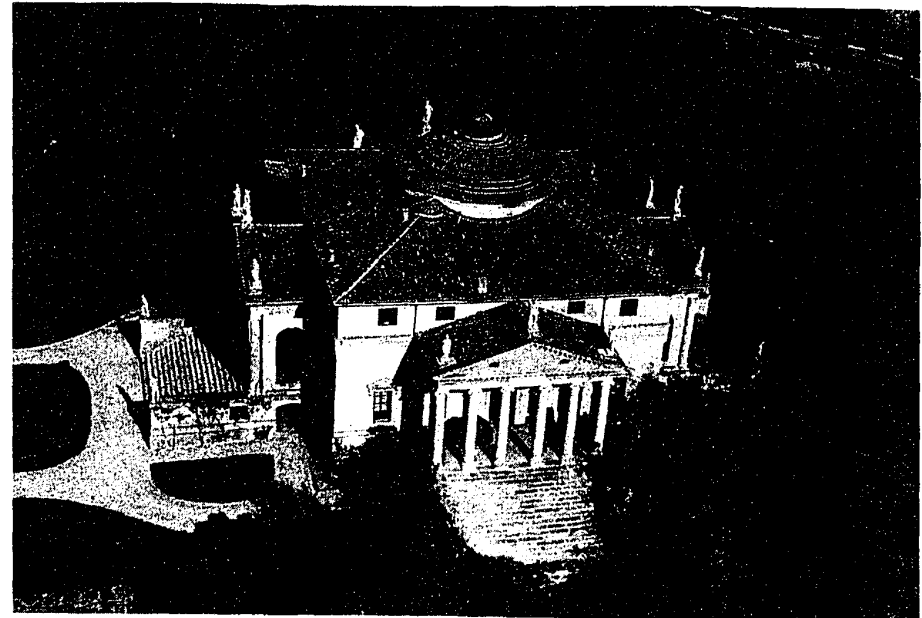
What de Botton tries to do is figure out why there have been, and still are, so many different styles of architecture. Why do some of us like one thing — let's say, glass-and-steel modernism — while others despise it? Why do so many Americans in 2007 wish to live in copies of the red-brick-white-trim Georgian architecture of the 18th century?

The author understands that sometimes we seek what is familiar, orderly, and predictable in the world we build, as in that Georgian house. But he also understands that sometimes we don't. Sometimes we seek the new, the shocking, the slightly crazy.

Both reactions are fine with de Botton. He's not interested in pushing one or the other. Instead he wants to figure out where our different tastes come from.

His answer is that every building embodies a message. It billboards a certain set of values.

"Buildings *speak*," he writes. "They speak of democracy or aristocracy, openness or arrogance, welcome or threat, a sympathy for the future or a hankering for the past." He could have added more such words. Buildings speak of risk-taking or cowardice, of individualism or conformity, of nature or artifice, of wealth or poverty, of handcraft or machinery, of the local or the global, of representation



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In designing Villa Rotonda (above) near Vicenza, Italy, the Italian Renaissance architect Palladio imitated the earlier work of Roman antiquity.

or abstraction, of permanence or change. And so on. We admire the buildings that speak our values — or, at least, the values we wish other people to perceive in us.

De Botton is not the first person to notice that works of architecture talk about cultural values. But for him this is a discovery and, as discoverers do, he writes about it with an engaging freshness.

The author makes one other major point. It's an obvious one, but it's often overlooked. It's simply that we seek, in our architecture, an antidote to the world we otherwise inhabit. That's why CEOs in Denver, who work in modernist glass-box downtown towers, drive home to traditional mansions that look like — and sometimes are — equestrian estates. That's why guys who work all day in a welding shop seldom want to live in a building that the architect, who has a crush on the "honesty" of the industrial look, has designed to resemble a factory.

Each "either" needs its "or."

De Botton likes both order and disorder. More than that, he wisely argues that you can't have one without the other. "Just as we cannot appreciate the attractions of safety without a background impression of danger, so, too, it is only in a building which flirts with confusion that we can apprehend the scale of our debt to our ordering capacities."

The book is filled with well-reproduced photos that always illustrate the author's argument. Some, like Villa Rotonda by the Italian Renaissance architect Palladio, are examples of how one age often imitates the work of a respected earlier one, in this case Roman antiquity. Others, like the Doge's Palace in Venice, not far from the Rotunda, are praised for striking a balance between too much order and too much chaos.

The biggest problem in architecture today is that nobody can agree on what's good or beautiful

and what's bad or ugly. It's a situation in which creative architects are often viewed with distrust by the public, and vice versa. De Botton's is a book that both sides can read with profit. It can bring them a little closer to consensus.

De Botton is an outsider in relation to architecture. Outsiders often see a subject more clearly than people who are up to their necks in it. The British author V.S. Pritchett said that best, in his autobiography: "For myself that is what a writer is — a man living on the other side of a frontier."

I can't recommend this book too highly. It gets just about everything right. I do suggest that the reader skim Chapter One. Chapter Two, on the other hand, which is titled "In What Style Shall We Build?" is a remarkable potted history of Western architecture.

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